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Howard Mandel

Howard Mandel was born in Chicago on December 26, 1950. The city's diverse range of jazz and blues inspired a passion for music journalism and he began his writing career with Down Beat *in 1974. Howard has written for* Billboard, the New York Times Book Review, *and founded The Jazz Journalists Association in 1992. He is an astute observer of the current jazz scene and author of the 1999 book* Future Jazz.

Howard was interviewed in Toronto, Canada on January 9, 2003 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Toronto filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive at the IAJE convention. I'm very pleased to have journalist Howard Mandel here.

HM: Thank you.

MR: It's a pleasure to meet you and I've been reading you for a number of years. So thanks for coming.

HM: Nice to be here.

MR: You know you and I are actually very close in age, and I think back when I was starting to listen to records and for some reason I was hearing like Little Eva and "The Locomotion." I'm wondering why you got into jazz, apparently at an early age?

HM: Well I was listening to Ramsey Lewis and "The In Crowd" and rhythm & blues music, it was on the local radio. I grew up in Chicago and I lived in a community that was on the South Side of Chicago so it was a neighborhood that was divided by Stony Island Avenue which is a large commercial street, and on one side was the black neighborhood and on the other side was the white neighborhood, but we went to the same grammar schools. And I just didn't understand what the distinction was, why there was this kind of divide in the community. And so I was curious about my black neighbors and playmates, schoolmates. And I liked the music from an early age. My parents had a few jazz records, they were not heavy listeners, they mostly listened to show tunes. But I liked, they had some Classical music, and I liked the Russians. I liked the drama. Rimsky-Korsakov, anything with the rhythm and the exotic colorations. And I heard that in some of the jazz music that I was exposed to also. And so I just gravitated to it very naturally. It just seemed like, yes I like instrumental music, I like this kind of rhythm & blues feel with the back beat, I liked it more than the country & western sort of influence that was coming in from Elvis and that level of rock & roll. And I liked the complexity. I was also an intellectual snob at an early age and I thought that the music that I was really interested in early, Miles Davis, some early Coltrane, Eric Dolphy around 1963, '64, it just seemed to

me akin to the movies I was watching, I was exposed to some early Truffaut and Goddard, that sort of thing. And I saw those kinds of connections. So I didn't really see it as like swing or bebop, I just knew it as dramatic, fractured, abstracted, fast, that sort of thing.

MR: I understand you took some piano.

HM: I had some piano lessons. When I was in high school I took some flute lessons. I still play flutes and a little bit of saxophone. In college I took some synthesizer courses and stuff like that.

MR: You mentioned being, you considered yourself an intellectual—

HM: An intellectual snob.

MR: An intellectual snob. Okay. Do you think that people, the general listening audience connects being intellectual snobs with jazz?

HM: Yeah. I'm afraid they do.

MR: Yeah?

HM: I mean I think that there's this mythology that you have to know everything about jazz or jazz is some sort of heady music that is not accessible readily. I've never understood that exactly. I mean it's so dramatic. I can understand it, when I would go to hear music by some of the aging, really the swing masters: Jimmy Forrest, Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis, guys like this. Now they were a little bit past their prime I supposed by the time I was hearing them in the late sixties. And they did not represent what I considered the avante garde. They were not taking structural chances. They were not playing the extremes of their horn. I didn't hear the vocalization in that that I'd heard in the "Art Ensemble." And I should backtrack a little bit. It was a matter of circumstance that I grew up near the University of Chicago where a lot of the AACM experimentation was being done, so it was someplace that I could go for an evening, my parents let me out with the car and we had moved to the northern suburbs, I didn't have any friends there, my friends were still on the south side, so it was someplace that I could meet or go to be near my previous home was the University of Chicago concert. So I heard Roscoe Mitchell and Lester Bowie and Muhal Richard Abrams. But then at the same time I thought well that's jazz and then here's this other jazz going on, Joe Siegel would put on Sunday afternoon concerts of these older swing tenor players, swing to bop tenor players. And I didn't understand it, it didn't attract me. It was a lot of notes. You know, the constant stream of eighth notes, sixteenth notes. I didn't hear the melodies being played. I didn't hear them pausing. It seemed to me that the songs were all very similar. The solos did not partake of the melody, they partook of the changes I learned later. But it just felt like they were running changes. And to me, that is inaccessible to the general audience. They do not understand why that's interesting. The notes seem even and consistent but they're not

making melodies, they're just making a lot of notes. And the interaction there, although I think the jazz people understand very well the kind of interaction that's going on, I think to the listener who's not exposed in a deep way, it sounds pro forma. And you do not hear the interaction between the drummer and the saxophonist and the pianist who's comping for the soloist. You don't hear it as something that's being created afresh. Now again, maybe it's because these guys were a little bit past their prime, they didn't have the fire.

MR: I don't know if — I know what you're saying because a lot of people say I like jazz until they stop playing the melody. And then they get in a sense lost because they don't know the form or they don't hear the tune anymore. But wouldn't you say that some of the older listeners would say some of those same comments about the AACM people?

HM: Well yes. I was interested in the narrative that the AACM was interested in developing, and the fact that it was a fragmentary or fragmented or I was able to follow that more easily. It seemed to have changes in it. It had more change because it was fractured or fragmented, as opposed to be bop-bop a bop-bop for ten minutes or twelve minutes or fifteen minutes, which didn't seem to have any change to me.

MR: But you're not talking about chord changes, you're talking about like emotional—

HM: No I'm talking about structure changes, emotional. The vividness and the drama again is really what I think I was caught up with originally. And the sort of maturity and the subtlety of a Lockjaw Davis or a Jimmy Forrest was a little bit lost on me. Because I didn't have any connection to the source material that they were taking off from. I mean I heard that is, American standards are corny; not necessarily corny. I liked them when Fred Astaire sang them, but I didn't feel like this is a vehicle for spilling out great new melodies. Now when Miles played them, the quintet music of the mid-fifties, which also I was exposed to as an early teenager, I liked that very much. But Miles is somebody who taps into the drama of a song and uses silence. He's not playing a steady stream of eighth notes, you know, or sixteenth notes. And the way he phrased, the vocal inflections, all that stuff I really connected with. I love that.

MR: You've mentioned the vocal connection. People, instrumentalists, using vocal — loss for words here — vocal inflections.

HM: Inflection, nuance.

MR: It seems very important to you.

HM: It was a way of connecting. I was not also taken with pop vocal music. It just didn't — I liked the rhythm & blues sound, I don't know why, the hoarseness maybe of some of the masculine baritone singers. I remember "Duke of Earl" very well, or "Alley-Oop" the Coasters. These are the kinds of songs that I liked. I was not into the ballads. I didn't care about Johnny Mathis that was hot at the time. I don't think I had been exposed to Jackie Wilson then. One of the first jazz vocals that I really remember, and this is again on my

parents' records, was Doris Day singing "Sentimental Journey" with Les Brown. And I really liked that. And it was on a sampler. Lucky Strike put out some sort of "This is Jazz" LP. And it also had Count Basie's "One O'clock Jump" on it which I liked a lot. And that sort of mystified me because it didn't have a melody at the beginning.

MR: Yeah, right.

HM: And so that gave me a sense that there was a way of arriving at something in a different structure, I mean that's okay? All right. I can buy that then. And I think this was one of my intellectual snobbery, and rock & roll and pop music just didn't seem, I don't know, sophisticated enough or interesting, and the singing, especially twelve, thirteen, when I was twelve and thirteen was when the Beatles came on the scene. And they were singing yeah-yeah-yeah and I was like no-no-no. You know, this is just too dumb. I'm more sophisticated than that. I read Hemingway or something.

MR: You must have been an avid reader.

HM: Yeah I was an avid reader. And that's really what led me into anything that I could pretend to be intellectual pursuits. Books and movies.

MR: Did your parents find it interesting that jazz music was interesting to you?

HM: They weren't put off by it particularly. They encouraged my aesthetic pursuits and my brother's. It was fine to have piano lessons at home. My dad I think had had piano lessons when he was a kid although he never pursued it very far, so they bought a piano. Presumably he was going to spend some time playing. I don't think he did. He was on the road. He was a traveling salesman so he was away a lot. But he would come in and play a few show tunes or something like that from very simple sheet music. And I was lucky that I eventually got with a piano teacher who showed me how to make chords and read a cheat sheet basically, instead of just reading classical music or something like that.

MR: What inspired you to pursue a career as a writer?

HM: Well I kind of have to give my dad a lot of appreciation for encouraging that. At one point a conversation I remember well, he and I were driving and he said have you thought about what you want to do when you grow up? I was maybe twelve or thirteen. And I said I don't know. And he said well when I was your age I wanted to be a writer. And again I thought that's okay? That would be okay? So he said to me at the time, the people who you're reading though, most of them were reporters first, and many of them were sports writers. I was reading Damon Runyon and Ring Lardner and also P.G. Wodehouse who I don't think was a sports writer. But I had very little interest in sports. I was a Cubs fan and they always seemed to be more like the Marx brothers than like a professional sports team. So I thought well I'm not too interested in sports but I could write about the movies, I could write about books. And I wrote about culture, I had a little newspaper when I was in sixth grade where I wrote movie reviews for my own little newspaper that

I was putting out. I was on the high school newspaper. And when we moved to the suburbs that was pretty good actually journalistic training. It was a weekly paper and it was substantial for a high school paper. And when I was in college also I was the counterculture editor of the college paper for a while, in Syracuse University. And of course there was a big explosion of music in the late sixties, and I did connect with pop music at that time, Jimi Hendrix, Aretha Franklin, Motown and some rock & roll, "Surrealistic Pillow" the Jefferson Airplane. I liked anything that was out. Anything that seemed psychological or seemed surreal was of interest to me. So some of the San Francisco bands like Quicksilver Messenger Service I remember I liked a lot. And the blues stuff from Chicago, even on the white side, Mike Bloomfield and Paul Butterfield. So that interested me. And more so than the British invasion. And of course it became possible to write about music. It seemed like especially the AACM music that I was hearing. I didn't see many people in the audience who would be in a position to write about it. I wasn't reading much about it. Terry Martin, John Litweiler and J.B. Fighy, the guys who were writing the liner notes for the Delmark records that were coming out were the only people who seemed to be acknowledging this music, which I just found fascinating. And I thought I could write something about this. If I just really concentrate on what I can be sure I know, and transmit just that, and try not to speculate and try not to put critical judgements on it that are — it was subject matter to me that I could express verbally on the page. And it seemed very dramatic. And of course you know when you're young if you want to be a writer, you really don't have much to write about. You can write about yourself and your teenage angst or something and I shunned that idea. And then I didn't have anything else to write about. So here was something that was not me but I was interested in and seemed so inherently dramatic. And the challenge of writing about sound. We can't see it, you can't touch it, so how do you describe it to somebody else in a way that's going to convey the sense of it. And that became — it was a challenge and I was interested in it and I began to focus on it. And I had a little bit of success in placing some articles. And I think it just was because I pursued listening to it so avidly. I went to the Ann Arbor blues and jazz festivals, I worked at the Jazz Record Mart in Chicago so I met several musicians.

MR: Basically getting to know the whole scene as much as you can. I mean you said an important thing there, to write only what you know or feel strongly about.

HM: Well I felt there was so much that I didn't know anything about, and especially when I was 18 to 25 or something. I mean it was just scratching the surface. I had no idea what this world was that the music was coming out of. And I was interested but I wanted to be very respectful, I was a little shy as outsiders are. I felt like it was okay to ask questions, that's the journalistic training I had. Ask a question. Find out. You are asking out of

curiosity. It's genuine and it's not displaying some sort of awkward egoness or even if it is so what. Nobody's going to find that out on the page. Whatever the experience is when you do the interview, that's not what you transmit to the page. You transmit to the page what you learned after the interview, what you've come out of it with. And I had ambitions to write fiction so I felt like it was perfectly okay to change the experience, not to change the information, but to change the narrator's stance. When I got to the page I didn't have to seem like I was 20 years old. I could seem like I was 25 or 30. And in fact I mean she may have been just flattering me but once I met Marian McPartland at a gig and introduced myself and she said, "Oh I've been reading you for several years I thought you were much older." And again I wanted to be in *Down Beat* at that time and I started writing for *Down Beat* in '74. And I didn't want to seem like the kid on the block, I wanted to write in a way that seemed like comparably mature to some of the older critics. To Leonard Feather. I didn't want to seem any less mature or knowledgeable than Leonard, whatever I was writing about. So I didn't want to come in with a gee whiz attitude. So I thought that was okay to take that liberty as a writer.

MR: Yeah. Is it harder to make a living as a jazz writer than it is as a jazz musician?

HM: Well I've never been a jazz musician. I think that's a pretty hard road to go too. Being friends with musicians, not just in jazz but contemporary composed music or chamber music, this is not an easy way to make a living. I do not find it easy to make a living as a jazz writer, no I don't. I've been doing it for 26, 27 years now, it hasn't gotten any easier. I think that in the last couple of years especially there has been a great sad drain of outlets. For a while when the dot com world was new and burgeoning there was a lot of work that could be done on the web, good outlets. There were magazines that sprung up and now have disappeared, most recently *Tower Pulse*. *Sound Aspects*, that Dan Ouellette was editing for a couple of years had been a good outlet, now it's gone. *Music and Sound Output* was another one that I was active with in the eighties. There's been a retraction of publications. It has to do with our general economy in the U.S., it has to do with raising postage rates, it has to do with competition from the web and television and movies. I think with the hegemony of major companies that are pumping out a lot of hype around big pop stars and less interest in smaller niche audiences, there are a lot of cultural reasons for it. Right now there is a big retraction of liner notes, and I've always enjoyed writing liner notes because when you do a liner note you really are being exposed to the music, you're one of the first people that gets exposed to it. And you kind of guide the listener who is going to buy this album into how to appreciate it, what went behind it. And if you write a good liner note I think it stays with the record for the life of the record. So I've liked doing that. But when they went from LPs to CDs, they turned the liner note from being a point of purchase stimulus.

MR: Yeah.

HM: When I would go through record stores I'd look at the liner note, read it standing there and decide whether I wanted to buy the thing or not.

MR: Absolutely.

HM: Well now they're on the inside of the jacket. You don't see them until after you've bought the CD. So I was afraid for a long time that the record companies would catch on that this was no longer a valuable service that the writers were providing. But now they just don't run liner notes because it's another couple hundred dollars to the production budget and they can't afford it.

MR: Wow that's unfortunate. And it's so true, because I did the same thing. You obviously can't hear the record when you're holding it, but you can read about it. And that's where I got a lot of my information, because there wasn't all the publications out back then, and it's a real art to writing good liner notes too.

HM: It was an art and I think it really influenced my writing. That's the nice thing. I mean liner notes were not — on rock records are very seldom any liner notes. If there were they were very jivey and hyped up. But on a jazz record, you're reading Ira Gitler or Dan Morgenstern or Nat Hentoff, you've learned something about how the music was put together and who these people were. And it really helped me to figure out what jazz writing was about, more than the classic books that were available in the sixties, Hodier or Panassie. This did not strike me as being true of the jazz experience as I knew it, what they were writing.

MR: Right. They were writing history.

HM: Histories and they were really from the thirties, they were French, they had a completely different frame of contacts and it didn't seem anything like what Chicago was in the fifties and sixties to me.

MR: I'm sure it wasn't.

HM: But Hentoff and Morgenstern and Gitler and a few other people touched on something that I could recognize.

MR: Right. When you are in this environment here at this jazz convention, it's probably unrealistic. It seems that the music is so healthy in this environment. What's your realistic view of where it's at?

HM: I think the music is very healthy. I think the industry is rather sick. I think we're in a time of great change as to how to disseminate this music and figuring out what function it serves, what's the social utility of jazz today. But I think that — realistically I do think that jazz permeates American culture and has made significant inroads into culture, basically all around the world. I think it's a very dynamic art form. I think it's a very adaptive art form. I think it's got a lot of strategies and techniques, tactics that can be

applied to many — that many people who want to express themselves can apply their own cultural material and their own internal feelings through the forms that jazz offers. And I think that that's been widely recognized. And I think that in Europe or in Asia or Australia or South America we are hearing musics that could only have been created after exposure to jazz. And I think in America, yes this festival gives us — or this convention gives us a somewhat skewered view. Here are all these people running around. But I mean I recognize you come to Toronto in January in kind of a recession that we're experiencing economically, this is the hard core of the jazz proponents here. They do represent a larger general overall market. But whenever I travel I hear jazz on the radio, I see it on TV, you don't see it like features, here's an hour of a jazz artist, but you hear it in commercials, you hear it in background music, you know it's the music of our time and of our country and I really think that it's impossible to ignore. It's a little bit like air, we just breathe it and we don't necessarily think about it all the time.

MR: I was reading something from an earlier interview and you were talking about country music, how it has such marketing power behind it and you mentioned a number of times the business aspect of jazz. Is there a way to make jazz close to being as popular as country music?

HM: I hope not. I mean not that I would not like to see jazz be popular but I don't think making jazz do anything is good for the art.

MR: That's a great thought I think.

HM: I mean I really trust jazz so much. Despite the challenges that the musicians have faced for a hundred years now, they have been able to really devote themselves to creating some incredible art that nobody could have made. Nobody except the artists themselves could have made it. No record executive could have told Louis Armstrong to go in and record the Hot Fives. You know? They just couldn't have imagined it. And I think that it's a lot easier for a record executive or producer to say to a country artist who is working off of ballad tradition, you know a storytelling narrative, why don't you turn your attention to this subject matter. Why don't we speed it up a little bit and put this kind of rhythm under it. Okay, we're talking about a formulaic sort of product and when record executives talk about jazz as product I just kind of cringe. Because that's not the way the good music has come about, whether we're talking about "Ascension" or "Kind of Blue" or "Love Supreme" or Prime Time, Ornette Coleman's stuff or Cecil Taylor's stuff, this is not music that can be — we're going to make this popular now by doing this to it. No, this is an art form. If you've got the expression as an artist and you can realize that expression you've done something that people are going to listen to for, I think hundreds of years. That's my thought about it. And if it connects to an audience immediately great, great. It should. It would be great if it could. But there is so much

between what the average listener, the common American, is ready to accept as music, and what the very sophisticated and very creative artist in sound is able to realize. There is so much gap between that that I really don't see that it's going to connect in an easy way. What with face paint? Or with an advertising campaign? It wouldn't hurt. It wouldn't hurt to demystify some of the stuff that goes into jazz, it would help. And I think jazz education is doing a good job with that. Not just the IAJE conferences but Newport, when I go to Rhode Island for the festival in August. Or Chicago where they have a free festival around Labor Day and they get ten thousand people out. Those people are not all devoted jazz fans but they get hooked in sometimes to some very strong, unusual music. I don't think that it's a music that you've got to be a Ph.D. to enjoy. I do think that there's a lot of sort of nonsense about what's good in music that kids, like I've got a ten year old daughter, that she gets exposed to on a regular basis from commercial media. And to overcome that, and to realize that there's other stuff too that's just not getting the commercial hype, that's not a thought that comes readily to a lot of people.

MR: Recently I've had a couple of conversations with musicians — white fellas in their let's say between 35 and 50, and they've made the comment that that's not a good thing to be in the jazz world these days. Middle aged white. Does that comment — a quick response.

HM: Well I think a lot of us feel like, as a middle aged white guy, it's work to keep up with the changes in our world. But I don't think that it's a bad thing to be trying to do that. Are they saying that they don't get respect from the musicians? Are you talking about musicians themselves?

MR: The musicians themselves.

HM: And they feel like — I don't know to me that sounds like an excuse. This is a music that comes out of an African-American basis. I've thought of it as an African-American gift to the world. And there's always been very strong white musicians back to Adrian Rollini up to Steve Lacy, Tim Berne, Dave Douglas, Myra Melford who I was hanging out with last night or Marilyn Crispell, Maria Schneider, or middle aged white guys I mean there are a lot of players who are quite strong. Marty Erlich, somebody who I enjoy quite a lot. You have to do something with the music. You can't just learn it and play it and expect people to — let's see — expect to say something significant. I think that any artist, and maybe people who are 35 to 50 are coming to grips with this in a really mature way, you have to say something that's of significance and you have to delve into yourself to find out what that is that you have to say. And it's not just like the energy of a 25 year old. I've got the chops, I've got the breath, and now I'm going to play for an hour. It's like well now what's important to say? What do we have to say that's lasting? And I think that that's a challenge that comes to any artist in any art form in middle age. So I think that they come to grips with the challenges. What does it mean to be white in America

playing a music that comes from an African-American basis? What does it mean to be middle aged and to be devoted to an art form that seems to be giving back very little in the way of monetary support? What distinguishes my work from his work, whether he's black, white, purple, Latin, whatever. And I think that those are difficult challenges that we have to face but I think that it's an excuse to say well I'm white and I'm middle aged so nobody cares about me. Well then make me care about you, you know? Tell me your story. Tell me what's really — because I'm white and middle aged so I would be interested in hearing what you have to say. We're still the baby boomers, the white, middle aged baby boomers are still the big part of the demographic. If you can't reach that demographic that's a big audience. If you can't reach them that means you're failing in your art form. And that's whether you're a movie maker, a choreographer, a novelist or a jazz musician.

MR: Well I think when you listen to commercials now that have jazz behind them, the people behind those commercials are recognizing who the buying power, where the buying power is.

HM: Yeah. They still think — commercials are still aimed at twenty year olds I think. The Gap commercials, where they're singing kind of a jazzy kind of melody and they pass it around amongst a bunch of young models comes to mind. Or the, I don't know what it is, I've seen commercials recently set in bars. There are a lot of commercials set in bars. And there's like some play back and forth between the guy and the girl at the bar and it's not always about liquor, it could be about something else. And I mean there's a lot of youth culture in our society and I think that that's kind of left over from the baby boomers too because we were the big demographic in '68, and if they can only get us to buy the new product. But now they're not trying to get us to buy the product that we can really use as fifty year olds. I guess they figure we know what we need as fifty year olds. And they also think that our tastes have solidified. There's the idea that when you're in middle age you know what you like and it's not going to change anymore. You're not going to grow in your aesthetic choices. That what you liked when you were twenty you're still going to like at twenty-five. I'm not sure that it's true. I don't know that it has to be true.

MR: Yeah. I was looking at a statement you had about — someone asked you about free jazz and I liked what you said and I wonder if you could just expand a little. You said, "Free to know a lot, free to be willing to investigate all possibilities, I think that's what free jazz is about." I thought that was a really interesting statement because some people including myself, if you said free jazz to me I would think of "Ascension" and Ornette Coleman's "Free Jazz" and records that are fairly hard to listen to, at least for me they were at the time. But do you have any thoughts about what free jazz means these days?

HM: Well I think the idea that jazz can be anything is an idea that has been widely accepted in the jazz community. Free jazz could be based on — not free jazz let me say jazz can be based on Balkan rhythms. Jazz can be inclusive of Chinese instruments. Jazz can be electronica. The idea that jazz is not just a three chord improvisation over swing rhythm, I think that idea has been widely accepted. And I think that when Ornette Coleman did the "Free Jazz" album, was it '62 or '63, that's what he was breaking out of, that jazz is just based on improvisation on standards. And I think now today we say jazz — you call it jazz, maybe it is. Or I say to my students if it's contemporary music instrumental played in America I'm going to call it jazz unless you can prove to me that it's not. How can you prove to me that it's not jazz? What doesn't it have in it that comes from jazz? Or what is the basis of it that's not that? How can you improvise in America on any basis other than the jazz basis? We have been so steeped in that for a hundred years. I mean bluegrass — I think bluegrass has some connection to jazz. Electronica, anything interesting that's happening in it comes out of jazz. I think that what you're referring to, Monk, the difficult music to listen to, what makes it difficult is that it provides the listener with an unfamiliar soundscape that the listener has to apply himself to or herself to, in order to make sense of. And not all of those soundscapes are immediately sensuous or embracing. I still find "Ascension" pretty difficult to listen to. It's a big, beautifully ugly piece of music. It's a raw, powerful wash of music. And most recently they released Coltrane's last live performance at the Olatunji Center. And that also is very — it's not a beautiful, classically beautiful saxophone sound. The guy is raging with an incredible amount of passion but to get close to that passion, to pull something out of it, I found it a valuable listening experience that way. "Free Jazz," the Ornette Coleman album, is only difficult because there's a lot of things going on at one time. And if you follow any one of those musicians through the piece it's not difficult. Dolphy plays delightful stuff throughout the entire piece. Ornette too. And Freddie Hubbard too and Don Cherry too. It's just that they're all happening at once. So can you make your mind large enough that you can kind of be in that playground. But there is a lot going on. To me that was never ugly.

MR: Well Dixieland did the same thing.

HM: Right, exactly. Yeah. Collaborative, spontaneous improvisation.

MR: Plus those guys were experimenting.

HM: They were. They were taking chances.

MR: Right. So I often times wonder if Coltrane thought that "Ascension" was a successful record. Maybe — I have not read whether or not his own opinion on it.

HM: Well I think that Coltrane was going for some — I don't think he ever made — I don't know. It strikes me that he had an ideal in mind that no realization was ever going to

reach, he was never going to attain. I think Coltrane had some very high standards. And the marvelous thing about Coltrane is that he tried to — he went for them. And just by going for them, however short he falls of actually having us ascend, you know, he gives us a platform so that we can begin to see what "Ascension" might really be. He gives us some sort of lift and launch. It's not all experimentation on those records either. I mean "Free Jazz," they released a twenty minute version that Ornette did as a first take. And it has all of the structural guideposts that are actually in the record. Ornette knows very well what he does before he does it. I mean I've sat in on Ornette's sessions. Ornette is a meticulous planner. And you can hear it even in the "Prime Time" stuff when it sounds like the sound is so large, there's so many different things happening, but they end on a downbeat. How did that do that? Well Ornette knows exactly what's happening. There is plenty of spontaneity but there's no — and there's surprises — but it's not free of — it's not just like a slice of okay now we're going to blow and see what happens. The Art Ensemble also. Meticulously arranged and very smartly segued from episode to episode. And there was space to improvise within the episodes, but they had a lot of turning points, a lot of structural things in place. I don't know who really does free jazz without any plan. I think that that's an idea — that we can just get up and blow — is something that amateurs believe, and some of those amateurs have tried to turn their work into careers and I think they fall short. Because unless you have a sense of where you're going, you're not going to be able to deliver. It's like taking a pizza out. Well I'm going to deliver it. I don't know where I'm going to go. Well if you're a pizza delivery guy — I do free delivery.

MR: And no one's going to enjoy it either.

HM: That's right.

MR: This could be a question you might need to think about, but if you could be a fly on the wall and go back in history, are there any moments that you wish you could have witnessed?

HM: Oh I would have like to have heard Jelly Roll live. That would be great. I found that, you know when I started listening I was listening to only the avante garde or what was considered the avante garde then. And now there is some traditional jazz, or the early classics, and I still don't feel like I understand and know how they are — I mean they give me a lot of joy to listen to Jelly Roll or the Hot Fives. And that's just as big a mystery to me as the Art Ensemble was when I first started listening to the Art Ensemble. So I would really like to have heard those. Red Allen is somebody I would have loved to have heard live during the thirties. I would have liked to have been on the recording session where Coleman Hawkins, Red Allen and Waymon Carver did the first flute solo on "Sweet Sue." That would have been fun for me. Oh what else? I try — I'm more

curious about what's going to happen basically than what's already happened. I would have like to have heard Charlie Parker live. That would have been great. I think I heard Charlie Parker when I was about two or three, on the radio. I think that was really like my first early memory of hearing a saxophone solo. And as much as I can recapture it now, I think it must have been Bird. I can't imagine who else it would have been. I heard Coltrane live. I guess I would like to revisit that because it was way over my head when I heard it. And actually Dave Liebman is going to give me a tape of that concert so I will get a chance to hear it again. I stood outside The Plugged Nickel when Miles was there with Wayne Shorter, Tony Williams, Ron Carter and Herbie. And I would have liked to have been able to go inside. I was too young to go inside.

MR: You were too young?

HM: Yeah. But I would have enjoyed that I think too. And Wes Montgomery. I wish I had caught the Half Note with Wynton Kelly. I would have really dug that.

MR: Yeah. I know my favorite guy is Cannonball. And I wonder if you ever saw him live?

HM: No I just barely missed him. He was going to play at the University of Illinois Chicago Circle Campus and then I think the concert got canceled. I don't think I ever saw him live. I like the album he did with Bill Evans.

MR: Yeah.

HM: "Know What I Mean" isn't that what it is?

MR: Yeah, "Know What I Mean." Sure.

HM: It's got "Waltz for Debby." Riverside. I like that a lot. I like Cannonball. I like the very last double album he did.

MR: "Lover" I think it was.

HM: Well I think that's the one that came out afterward. I think there was one before that. He had played "Streets of New York" and — a very good album, very underrated musician in a lot of ways. And Nat wrote some really great tunes.

MR: Oh, I guess he did. Tell me about the Jazz Journalists Association. Do you think that there's a responsibility. Let me rephrase that — some musicians don't like critics.

HM: So I've heard.

MR: You know? I don't understand why. Do you think that they have reasons for that that are legitimate?

HM: Oh sure. Nobody likes to be told that their hands are dirty. That's what criticism means. You mother is saying, "Go wash your hands again before you come to dinner." That's why we call it the jazz journalists instead of critics. There is really very little serious criticism that's done in the name of publication work anyway these days. I think that like any profession the jazz journalists are still learning how to do what they do, and they're not all at the top of their metier. I think that there's no training in music journalism and

certainly in jazz journalism or music criticism. So a lot of us just kind of stumble around trying to figure out how to do it and how to do it right and how to do it well. So I think that the musicians have a point when they say well this guy doesn't know what he's talking about. Not all of us do know what we're talking about. That's not to criticize my colleagues, that's to give them credit for trying to talk about something which as I said before is quite elusive, quite ethereal and insubstantial. And how to put it into words is a difficult thing to figure out how to do. Now that said, the musicians have their own point of view. We are not necessarily writing for musicians to be musicians. I don't believe that. I think we're writing for other listeners, to try to inform and guide those listeners to the kinds of things that the revelations and the experience that we've had that we think are worth transmitting. And positive insightful or negative insightful criticism serves a real function. Somebody said after Oscar Peterson's diatribe last night I guess — which I didn't hear — against jazz journalists, well this is what he opened up with when he was given his award, it became an attack on jazz critics. And I'm sure Oscar Peterson has had some bad reviews, but I can't say that he's suffered from jazz criticism.

MR: Right.

HM: And I think that his perspective on what he does — I do not think that musicians share the perspective that jazz critics share on the music. Musicians are focused on what they're doing and they understand what they're doing internally. They're not necessarily able to articulate it, and we're not looking to them to do that. I think a good jazz journalist who is doing interviews helps the musician to articulate what they're doing for the reader. But we can help them because we're supposed to be good with words the way they are good with music. I think that most creative artists are not what we call objective about other artists. They are doing what they do because they have a passion for it and they think that that's the thing that needs to be done, and therefore what the other guy is doing is slightly wrong. If the other guy was going it just the way they were doing it well that would be better except they would be copy cats. So I mean it's interesting when you read jazz journalism or writing by a musician. Rex Stewart in *Down Beat* or oh, who's the pianist out of Chicago, the traditional pianist — Art Hodes. You know they have very strong points of view. But it's not necessarily a point of view that's going to transfer to just the curious listener. It's like talking to somebody who's already got a hand in the game and they have an agenda. So that sort of takes it out of the realm of journalism to me. And it doesn't make a criticism that I could necessarily trust, although the musician could be quite enlightening about what his colleagues are doing, whether he likes it or not. But then I have to decide whether it's worth doing as a listener for myself.

MR: Do you find it difficult sometimes to let's say reign in your own opinions about whether songs, particular songs from artists have a meaning beyond the music? And what I mean

521 by that, I heard this anecdote about a critic who had written about Albert Ayler and was
522 imposing his own feelings about the music that Albert was playing about oppression and
523 his passion and the whole thing, and that Albert read that and said, "That's not what I was
524 thinking at all, I was just playing." So to shorten the question, do you ever have a
525 circumstance where you have to say to yourself maybe this isn't what this person was
526 about at all?
527 HM: I've had that circumstance but I don't necessarily try to reign it in I just try to clue in the
528 reader that maybe this is coming from me. I think that whatever the art suggests to the
529 perceiver of the art is valid. At least to that perceiver it's valid. And then we can debate
530 about what — the interpretation is one of the things that critics or journalists, particularly
531 critics, are supposed to be about. Interpreting the art. It's not just describing it. If we were
532 going to describe it then we should all have the degrees in music theory so that we can
533 work in music notation, and you know the *Down Beat* reviews would be filled with music
534 notation. And then he does this. It's interpretation and making the jump from what this
535 sounds like to me, what this might mean to you. What this might mean to our society.
536 What it means in the context. What it means to the guy who created it. What the intention
537 is, but what the interpretations can be and what the ramifications can be. That makes
538 interesting reading to me.
539 MR: Well a good listener and reader I think could profit from finding a critic or journalist that
540 seems to be on the same wavelength as them, and if they like particular records it's going
541 to be a good chance that I'm going to enjoy that.
542 HM: I think the consumer guide aspect of jazz journalism is valuable if it functions in that
543 way. I like to be a little bit ahead of my readers. I hope I can suggest things to them that
544 they haven't though of before. I mean I want to be — not always provocative or inspiring
545 but I want to be more insightful. I have a lot of experience listening. That's what I try to
546 do seriously for a living so I hope I can bring something to them they haven't thought of
547 before. I want to be on the same wavelength with them but I don't want to hold myself
548 above my reader. And I don't want to hold myself above the musician who is the creator
549 whose work I'm considering. I want to be a mediator somehow between them. And I
550 think that that means that I have to communicate with the musician either by listening or
551 by actually talking to them. And I need to communicate to my reader by writing clearly
552 and vividly in a way that they enjoy reading, that they're going to keep reading to get to
553 the end. That's a writer's job. So this is something that we try to kind of talk about in the
554 Jazz Journalists Association to some extent. We're doing clinics today, Thursday, Friday,
555 Saturday with young aspiring jazz journalists and we hope to impart some of the basics of
556 what we're doing to them, do a little mentoring or guidance for people who are writing,
557 talk to them about the realities of working in jazz journalism, offering them the benefits

of our vast experience. The networking aspect, the Jazz Journalists Association started in '85 at a meeting in Chicago that brought together writers and broadcasters. I think it was sponsored by the NEA. And we decided that we should have some sort of organization, mostly just for networking purposes. So if we go to a city that we're not familiar with for a festival we've got somebody to go out to dinner with. And it's worked very well that way. And of course I think that jazz journalists have often been people who did not engage successfully in social functions as teenagers. You know, instead they sat in their rooms listening to their records. And I think that giving them a safe social forum is a good thing and suggest to them that this is not a sin that they're sitting listening to their records but that a lot of us do it and it's sort of a normal behavior and it's got a valuable place in our society. They don't have to hide it or be ashamed of it, and that they could actually ask for decent money or working conditions, you know, if they're going to pursue this that they are professionals, that they can meet some professional standards and we can talk about what kind of professional standards we'd like to see imposed on our profession, like to be established. So it's worked in a lot of those ways. And also informs the general public and the musician about what it is we do. We do that through out web site, we expose a lot of new music. It's the journalists who discover the talent and bring it to the attention of the record companies often, the booking agents, the concert producers. If I get enthusiastic about a young band I let people know about it. Gonzalo Rubalcaba, who I've written about quite a lot, I heard him in '85 in Berlin when he was doing his electric Cuban sort of fusion thing. And I didn't think so much of it at that time. Then I guess I heard about him through Charlie Haden, mentioned him to me, and I saw him do a recording here in Toronto when he couldn't come into the US. I was invited to go to the studio and hear him with DeJohnette and Charlie Haden and I thought it was great. "The Blessing" is the album that came out of that. And I started writing about him and I think he's just a wonderful pianist and I've followed his career and I think he's a substantial performer. I've written about him a couple of times for *Down Beat* and I've written about him for other publications, and I guess I've written his liner notes also. And after a while it accrues some substance to support this person. If Howard Mandel likes him in this way, well maybe there's something there we should pay some attention to. Don Pullen. Andrew Hill. Andrew is very grateful to me and I'm proud of that. Andrew says you stopped writing about me — "All the articles until you wrote about me, Howard, were about me as a performer in the sixties. You brought me up to date." And I don't know I think I've been very lucky to run into some musicians I could do that with. Sonny Criss, I wrote about for *Down Beat* early on. I took Grover Washington seriously and he was grateful for that and I think Grover was not Charlie Parker but he's a decent musician and he deserves some respect that way. So I don't

know I think I got a little off there. But there are things that jazz journalists do for the art form. We are the historians. We are writing the history in the moment that it's happening. We're not waiting until everybody's dead and then trying to go back and do the research. We're out there on the front lines, seeing concerts, at the clubs, getting the records and we're telling you what's happening now. We may not be benefiting from having a historical perspective but I think that we're benefiting from being there as it's going down. And this is music that takes place in the moment and I think it deserves to have reportage from the moment. You don't report a war six years later. You report it from the front lines. And this is not a war, this is a cultural creation and it's exciting to be there while it's being created and bringing back these nuggets about what happened, how it happened, who did it, what they were thinking. It's the same five — who, what, when, where and why thing — and we can apply it to the creation of an art. It's very exciting.

MR: Good statement.

HM: Thank you.

MR: And *Down Beat*'s been around for an awful long time. Is it healthy? A good future for it?

HM: Oh — now you're going to get me in trouble. I think actually *DownBeat* has made some changes recently that I'm not really at liberty to talk about but I think they are about to announce a change in the publisher that I think will be good for it. *DownBeat* is in some ways frustrating. *Down Beat* could have been *Rolling Stone*. *DownBeat* was the music magazine before there were music magazines in this country. *DownBeat* could have been *Spin*. It has to do with the — dare I say — narrow ambitions of the publications that did not grow in that way and thrive in that way. Now it's given birth to *Jazz Times* and *Jazziz*. But I don't think it's served the music in the way that it might have. I wish it will. I hope it will sometime. And it's not the only publication — I mean I've worked with them since '74 but I have written for *Jazz Times* and *Jazziz*, and really anybody who'd pay me. *Swing Journal*, *The Wire*, *Witme*, which is a Finnish jazz magazine, *Bravo* from Brazil, Italian jazz magazines, Swiss magazines. There's a lot of journalism and publication about the music but it's very scattered and seldom in one place. We are seeing a lot of great jazz writing in book form now, and that's very unusual. That was not happening twenty years ago. It's very difficult — I don't think that the publishers are making a lot of money on most of the jazz biographies and collections, histories that are coming out but they seem to be willing to take a chance on it. I think that's a good thing.

MR: Great. Well I know you have to get going and I appreciate your conversation today.

HM: My pleasure.

MR: Keep doing what you're doing.

HM: Oh, like I have a choice. Thanks Monk.